

CEBT Style and Usage Guide

Our Standards

To maintain consistency and enhance readability, we follow

- [18F Content Guide](#)
- [The Chicago Manual of Style](#)

General Rules

- Consistency is key, whenever possible.
- It is acceptable to be inconsistent if it makes the content clearer and simpler.

CEBT-Specific Style and Usage

The following are GSA/CEBT-specific style and usage guidelines not designated in the *18F Content Guide* or *CMOS*.

Abbreviations, Units, and Measures

45 °F	Use the symbol instead of spelling out the word degree.
45 V	Add a space after the number, before the unit.
> 5 <	Use < or > rather than spelled out words. Add a space before and after the symbol.
\$10,000/yr	Use a "/" instead of the word "per."
etc.	Avoid using. Instead, use "and others" or "and more", if needed.
ft	Do not punctuate, as in "ft."
ft ²	Use superscript, instead of sq ft or sf.
kWh	Use to denote a kilowatt hour: \$0.12/kWh

million	Generally, spell out in body copy.
M	Abbreviate in bulleted lists or illustrations (i.e., tables, figures).
numbers	Use numbers when associated with a unit of measurement: 7 years, 3 centimeters
U.S.	Abbreviation for the United States, with the punctuations.
vs.	Spell out as <i>versus</i> , except when referencing legal cases as in Aardvark vs. Squiggly.

Footnotes and References

Multiple footnotes	Avoid using more than one note reference at a single location (such as 5,6). A single note can contain more than one citation or comment.
Footnotes in body copy	Footnote references should appear after the punctuation, except with dashes: <i>as seen here</i> . ⁶
References	Use the “author-date” basic format, punctuated with periods. For example: DOE. 2019. “FEMP Wireless Occupancy Sensors for Lighting Controls: An Applications Guide for Federal Facility Managers.” Newsham, G., Macinini S., and Marchand, R. 2008. “Detection and Acceptance of Demand-Responsive Lighting in Offices with and without Daylight.” <i>Leukos</i>, Issue 4. See Chicago Manual of Style, Section 15, specifically 15.5 for explanations and variations.
Citations, in copy	Use the “author-date” basic format. For example: <i>Lighting controls vary the light in a space by automatically turning lights on/off. (Newsham, Macinini, and Marchand 2008)</i>

Names, Words, and Phrases

and/or	Use sparingly. Decide which is most appropriate and use one or the other. In some cases, "and/or" makes sense.
contractions	Use on a case-by-case basis. Can make content sound more natural and relaxed and reading more enjoyable.
cost-effective	Always hyphenate.
dates	To avoid confusion, spell out specific dates: <i>October 11, 2023</i>
delta T	Do not hyphenate.
makeup	Use one word: <i>makeup water</i>
email	Use as one word, no hyphen, whether noun or adjective.
GSA	Remember the "s" in General Services Administration. Do not include <i>the</i> before acronym (GSA) or General Services Administration.
net zero	Use two words: <i>These technologies are well suited for helping us reach net zero.</i>
net-zero	Hyphenate when used as an adjectival phrase: <i>net-zero emissions goals for federal buildings</i>
online, offline	Use one word, no hyphen, whether noun, adjective, or verb.
onsite	Use as one word: <i>GSA installed the technology onsite.</i>
on-site	Hyphenate when used as an adjectival phrase: <i>on-site specialists.</i>
set up	Two words when used as a verb: <i>I helped set up the lighting system.</i>
setup	One word when used as a noun: <i>That was a quick HVAC setup.</i>
testbed	Use as one word: <i>The testbed was in a colder climate.</i>
test-bed	Hyphenate when used as an adjectival phrase: <i>test-bed environment</i>
utilize	Avoid using. In most cases, it can be replaced with the word "use," which is often more appropriate and correct.

shall, should	Avoid using. Use "will need to" instead.
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Using Dashes

- hyphen	Use for joining two words into one: <i>user-centered design</i>
– en dash	Use for number or date range separation: <i>10–20 units</i>
— em dash	Use for offsetting a phrase: <i>CEBT's three programs—GPG, P2P, and AILL—enable GSA to make sound investment decisions in next-generation building technologies based on their real-world performance.</i>

ly	In most cases "ly" adverbs are sufficient modifiers and therefore do not need hyphenation. However, when the "ly" is not an adverb then a hyphen is recommended, such as: <i>twice-weekly</i> or <i>family-friendly</i>
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